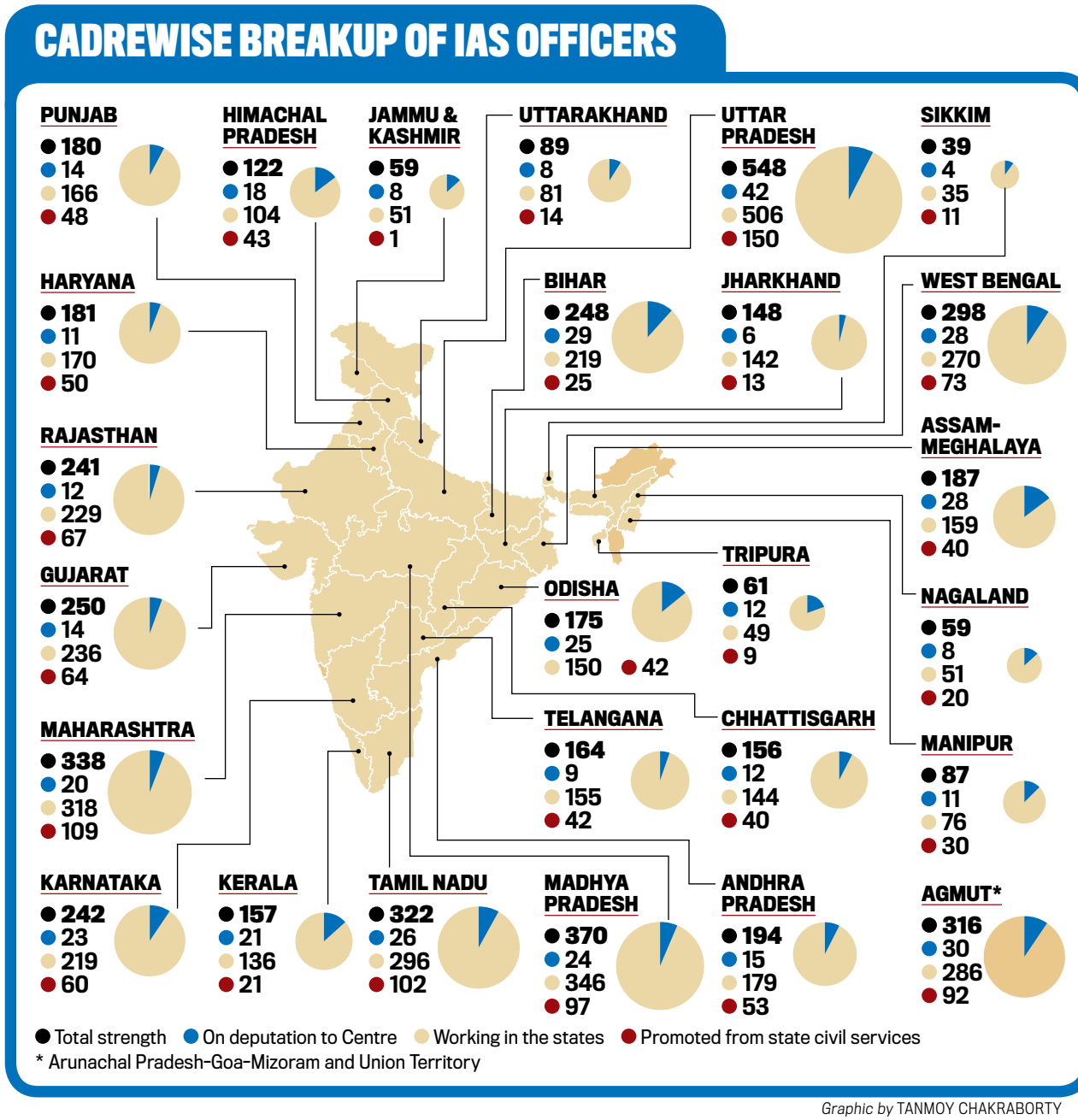


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

term damage to the polity." Yet others say that the problem is that a majority of officers do not want to work outside their state. They cite two reasons for it. One, the empanelment process is itself pitted against those going to the Union government. Two, the cadre develop a comfort in the state and do not want to take on an unknown (the Centre). Consequently, the AIS has effectively devolved into the provincial services.

"There is no premium on competence in the civil service. That is the problem. It is a self-imposed characteristic or virtue rather than externally demanded. What is demanded by bosses is only subservience," emphasises P.V. Ramesh, who retired from the Andhra Pradesh cadre. People choose to refer to the IAS as the steel frame but actually it is no frame at all, he says, likening bureaucrats to multiple amoebae put in a bowl and moving in different directions.

Ramesh suggests an overhaul of the governance structure (which has not been attempted in the past 75 years) as the IAS is too small for a complex country of 1.4 billion people. His solution: do not allot to a cadre for the first 12-14 years when you are expected to do field service and earn your spurs to go to the next level. At that stage, let an independent national civil service authority appraise performance along with the UPSC and decide the direction in which each one should go. Also make it mandatory for the officer to work with the Union government for a couple of years and only on completing it should the officer be allotted to any state. He feels the staff position should be national in an All India Service in order to have a bureaucracy that is independent and stands up for the rule of law while being part of the nation-building enterprise. ■

with Amitabh Srivastava, Rohit Parihar and Romita Datta